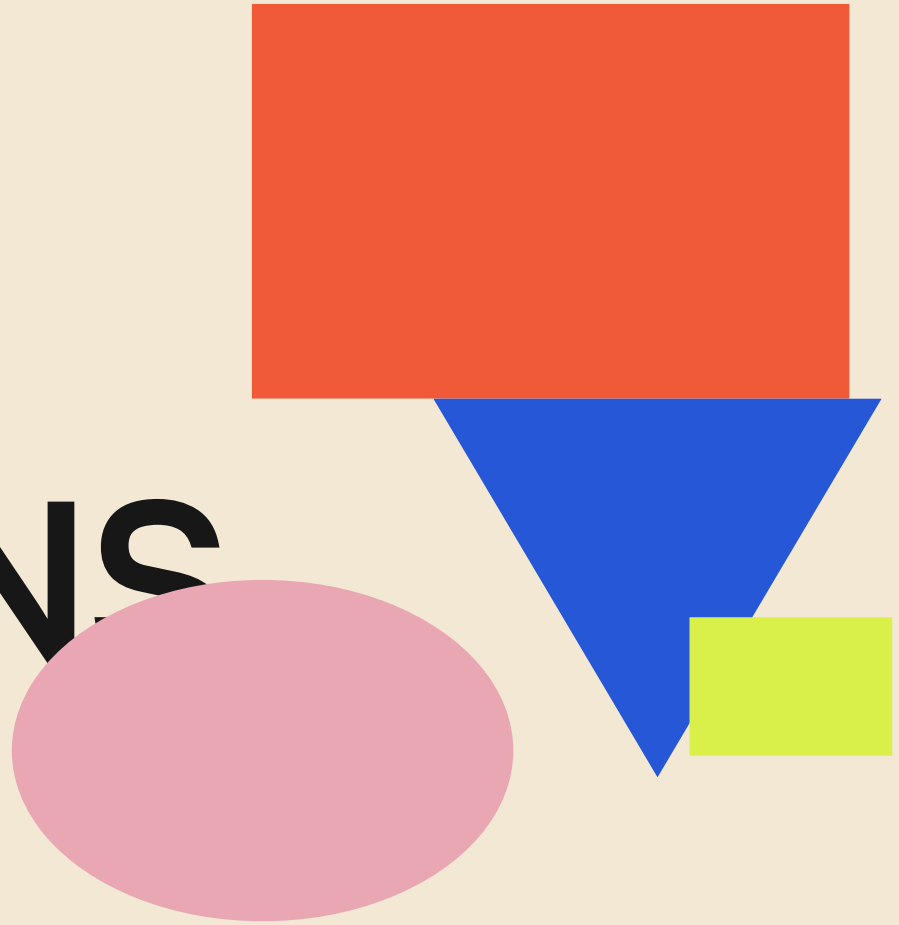
DATA SYSTEMS ADMINISTRATOR COURSE · MODULE 01

WINDOWS FOUNDATIONS

From your first login to your first remote fix.

Entry level · Hands-on · No prior IT experience needed



COURSE MAP

8 STOPS ON YOUR FIRST TOUR

8

stops around Windows, zero guesswork

01 Navigation — move around without getting lost

02 Lock Screen — your PC's front door

03 The Desktop — your workbench, part by part

04 Settings — where Windows keeps its controls

05 Task Manager — see what your PC is doing right now

06 Software Center — the company app store

07 Remote Desktop (RDP) — drive a PC you can't touch

08 File Explorer — find, move, and organize files

STOP 01 · NAVIGATION

THREE TOOLS GET YOU ANYWHERE

Getting lost in Windows is normal — admins just know the three exits.

3

tools to find anything on the PC



01 START MENU

Click the Windows icon or press the Win key. Every app on the PC is listed here.

02 SEARCH

Press Win and just start typing — "Wi-Fi", "printer", "settings". Windows finds it for you.

03 TASKBAR

The strip along the bottom of the screen. It shows what's open and holds your pinned favorites.

PRO MOVE Right-click the Start button for a hidden admin shortcut menu.

STOP 01 · NAVIGATION

SIX SHORTCUTS WORTH MEMORIZING

6

key combos that save your shift

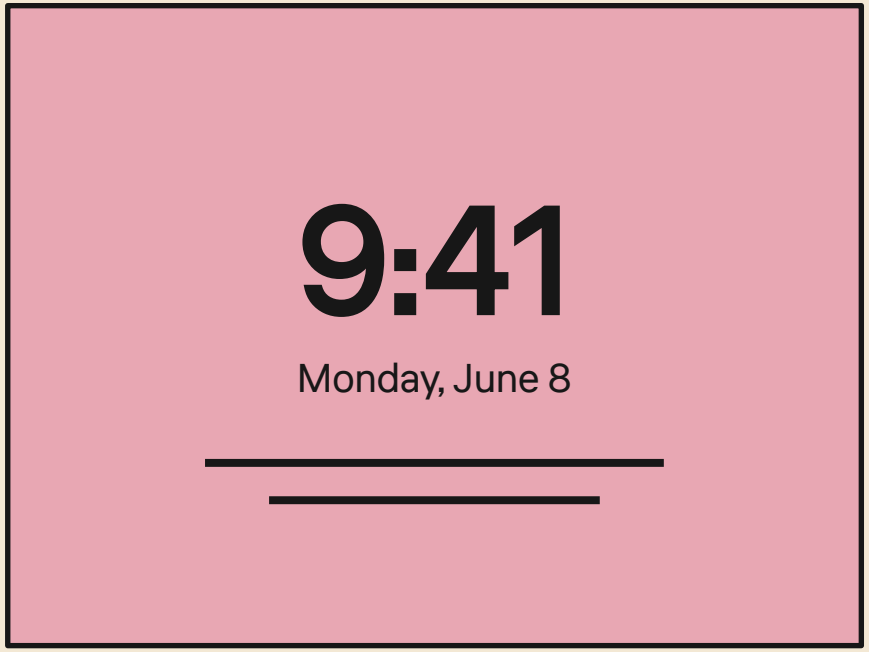
Win	Open Start, then type to search anything
Win + D	Show the Desktop instantly
Alt + Tab	Switch between open windows
Win + E	Open File Explorer
Win + L	Lock your PC (more on this next)
Ctrl + Shift + Esc	Open Task Manager directly

Start with three — Win, Alt + Tab, and Win + L. The rest will stick with practice.

STOP 02 · LOCK SCREEN

YOUR PC'S FRONT DOOR

The lock screen is what Windows shows before anyone signs in — it greets you, and it guards the PC.



Schematic — yours will show your own picture, clock, and chosen notifications.

WHAT IT SHOWS

Time, date, battery, network, and the notifications you choose to allow.

HOW YOU GET IN

Click or press any key, then sign in with your password or PIN.

THE GOLDEN RULE

Press Win + L every time you step away. Even for coffee.

Why admins care — an unlocked, unattended PC is an open door to company data.

LOCK IT. EVERY TIME.

THE HABITS

Stepping away?

Lock it. Win + L takes one second and protects everything open.

Sharing a lab or office?

Lock it. Curiosity isn't malice, but it's still a risk.

Done for the day?

Sign out — don't just close the lid and walk off.

Lock screen ≠ signed out — your apps keep running underneath while it's locked.

Sign-in options — a password works anywhere; a PIN works on this PC only.

STOP 03 · THE DESKTOP

MEET YOUR WORKBENCH

The desktop is your home base — here's what each part is called and does.

1 **ICONS**

Shortcuts to apps, files, and folders. Double-click to open.

2 **WALLPAPER**

The background image — yours to change (we'll see how in Settings).

3 **START BUTTON**

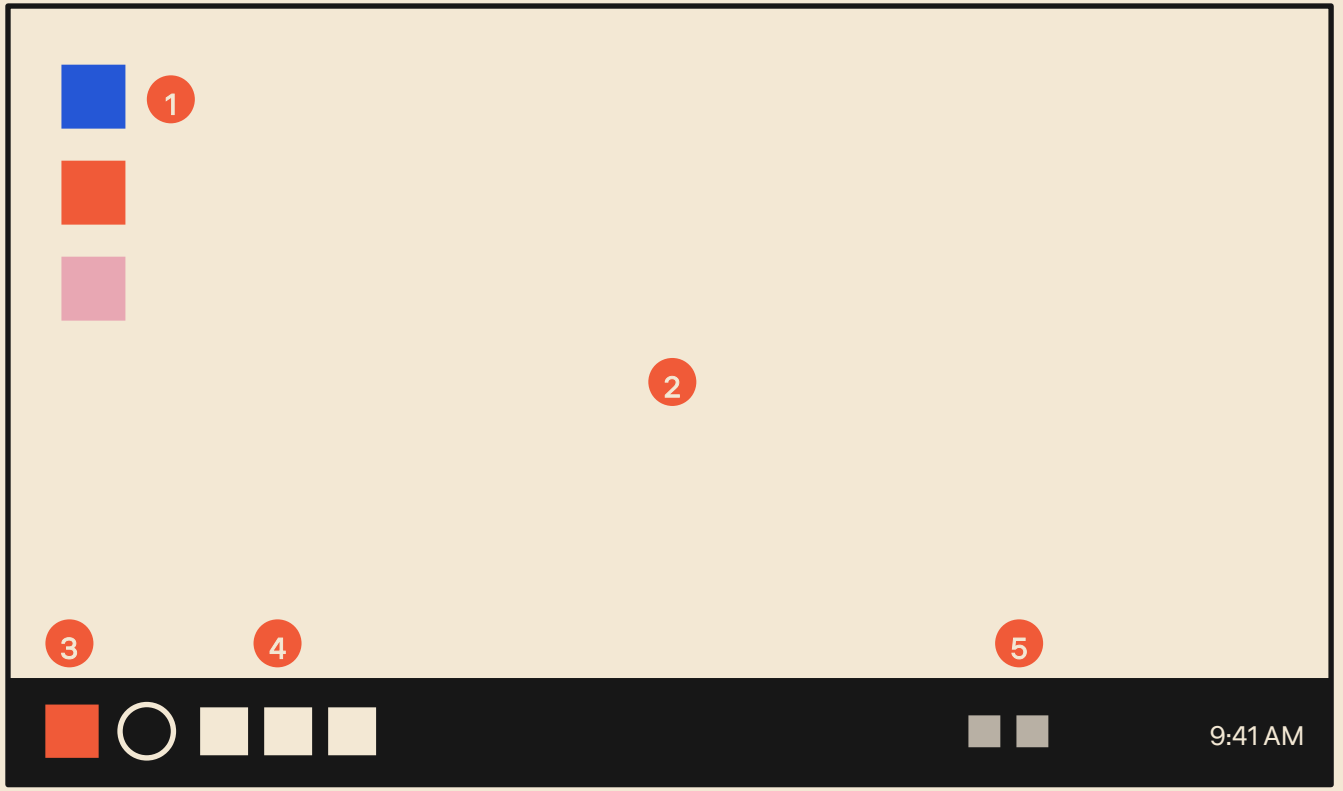
Bottom-left of the taskbar — the front door to every app and setting.

4 **PINNED & OPEN APPS**

Your pinned favorites. A line under an icon means it's running.

5 **TRAY & CLOCK**

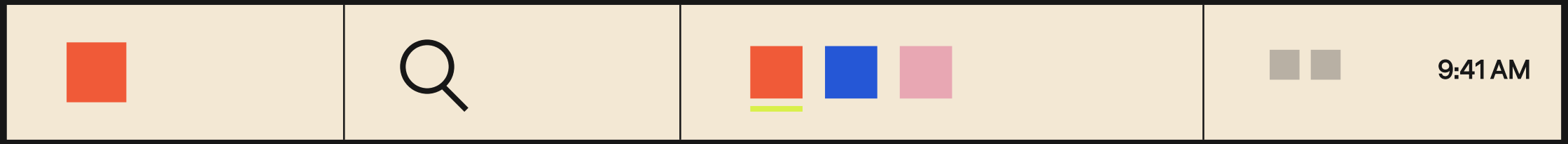
Wi-Fi, volume, battery, and time — click the corner for quick settings.



Schematic — your desktop will look busier; the zones never change.

STOP 03 · THE DESKTOP

THE TASKBAR, ZONE BY ZONE



1 · START

Every app and setting on the PC starts here.

2 · SEARCH

Type a few letters to find apps, files, and settings.

3 · PINNED & RUNNING

Pinned favorites live here. A line under an icon means the app is open.

4 · TRAY & CLOCK

Wi-Fi, volume, battery, time. Click the corner for quick settings.

Pin your top five tools: right-click any app → Pin to taskbar.

STOP 04 · SETTINGS

ONE MENU RUNS THE WHOLE PC

The Settings app is where you change how Windows looks, connects, updates, and behaves.

HOW TO OPEN IT

Press Win + I

The fastest way — works from anywhere.

Start → Settings

Look for the little gear icon.

Right-click Start → Settings

The admin shortcut menu strikes again.

Don't browse — search.

Type what you want in the Settings search box — "display", "password", "Wi-Fi" — and jump straight to it.



Schematic — categories down the side, search on top.

STOP 04 · SETTINGS

THE FIVE PANELS YOU'LL LIVE IN

5

panels cover most of your week

SYSTEM	Display, sound, storage, battery, and "About this PC".
NETWORK & INTERNET	Wi-Fi, Ethernet, VPN, and airplane mode.
ACCOUNTS	Sign-in options, password & PIN, and other users.
WINDOWS UPDATE	Security patches and restart scheduling.
PERSONALIZATION	Wallpaper, colors, and the lock screen picture.

Control Panel still exists for old-school tools — Settings covers about 90% of daily admin work.

STOP 05 · TASK MANAGER

YOUR PC'S DASHBOARD

Task Manager shows everything running on the PC and how hard each part is working. It's your first stop when something feels slow or stuck.

OPEN IT **Ctrl + Shift + Esc** (fastest) · Ctrl + Alt + Del → Task Manager · right-click the taskbar

PROCESSES	Everything running right now, and how much CPU and memory each one is using.
PERFORMANCE	Live graphs for CPU, memory, disk, and network — the PC's vital signs.
STARTUP APPS	What launches itself at sign-in — disabling heavy ones speeds up boot.
USERS	Who is signed in and what they're running — useful on shared machines.

STOP 05 · TASK MANAGER · DEMO

UNFREEZE AN APP IN 4 STEPS

1 **Open Task Manager**

Ctrl + Shift + Esc — one hand, three keys.

2 **Find the app on the Processes tab**

Look for the words "Not responding" next to its name.

3 **Click it once, then click End task**

Windows closes just that app — nothing else.

4 **Reopen the app and carry on**

Unsaved work inside that app is gone; everything else is safe.

YOU DID IT RIGHT IF

The frozen window closes and your other apps stay open.

LAST RESORT RULE

Wait 30 seconds first — many apps recover on their own. End task throws away unsaved work in that app only.

STOP 06 · SOFTWARE CENTER

THE COMPANY APP STORE

Software Center is where your organization hands out approved apps. Install what you need — no admin password, no sketchy downloads.

HOW IT WORKS

1 **Find it**

Press Win, type "Software Center", hit Enter.

2 **Pick your app**

Browse or search the approved list — like an app store.

3 **Click Install**

It downloads, installs, and keeps itself updated.

WHY IT EXISTS

APPROVED & SAFE

IT has checked every app on the list before you see it.

NO PASSWORD NEEDED

Standard users can install from it — no admin rights required.

LICENSES HANDLED

No keys to type, no paperwork for you — IT manages it.

Can't find what you need? Request it from IT — don't install random internet downloads.

STOP 06 · SOFTWARE CENTER

GET APPS THE SAFE WAY

DO

Install work apps from Software Center.

Say yes when updates prompt you.

Restart when updates ask — patches protect you.

Request tools you can't find from IT.

DON'T

Download installers from random websites.

Click "Free download!" ads and pop-ups.

Share licensed installers with friends.

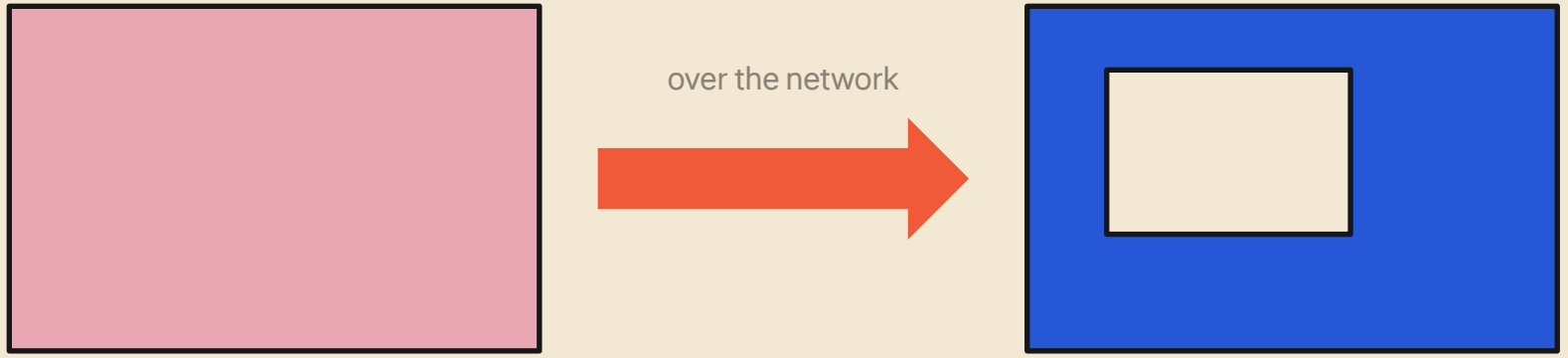
Snooze restart prompts for days.

Unapproved software is the #1 way malware walks into a company.

STOP 07 · REMOTE DESKTOP (RDP)

DRIVE A PC YOU CAN'T TOUCH

Remote Desktop Protocol (RDP) shows another Windows PC's screen in a window on yours — and lets you control it as if you were sitting there.



Its screen appears in a window on yours — mouse and keyboard work on both.

WHEN ADMINS USE IT

Fix a user's PC without leaving your desk.

Manage servers that have no monitor attached.

Reach your work PC from home.

Needs — the remote PC powered on, on the network, set to allow Remote Desktop, and permission for you.

STOP 07 · REMOTE DESKTOP (RDP)

CONNECT IN FOUR MOVES

1 **Open the tool**

Press Win, type "Remote Desktop Connection" (or mstsc), hit Enter.

2 **Name the machine**

Type its computer name or IP address, then Connect.

3 **Sign in**

Use your own username and password — never someone else's.

4 **Finish right**

Sign out. Just closing the window leaves you logged in on that machine.

SAFETY RULES

Authorized machines only — connecting is a permission, not a right.

Never save passwords on shared or lab PCs.

Always sign out when the work is done.

STOP 08 · FILE EXPLORER

EVERY FILE LIVES SOMEWHERE

File Explorer is the filing cabinet of Windows — press Win + E to open it. Here's the layout.

1 RIBBON

Actions — copy, move, rename, delete, new folder.

2 ADDRESS BAR

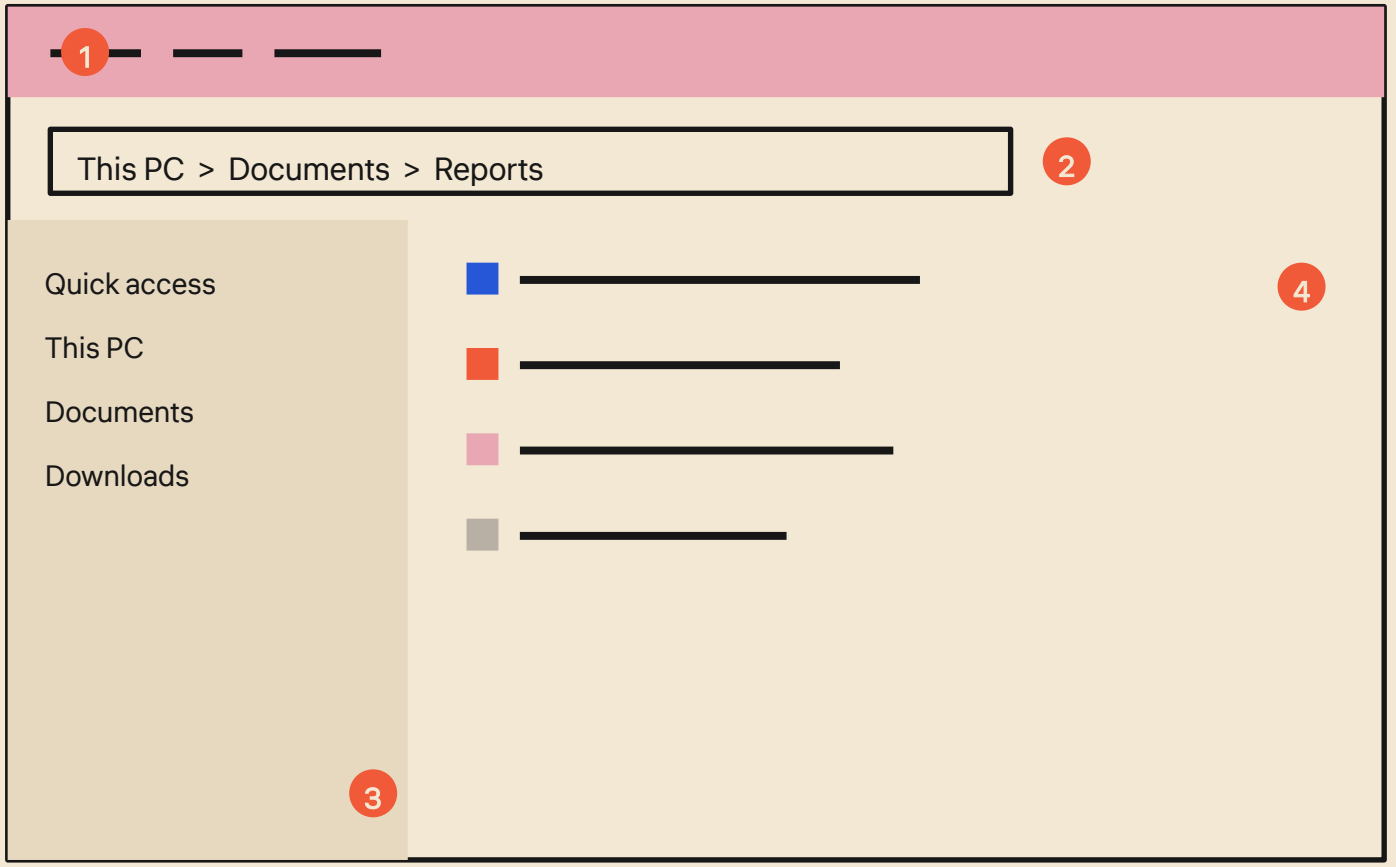
Where you are right now — click a crumb to jump back.

3 NAVIGATION PANE

Shortcuts to Quick access, This PC, and your folders.

4 FILE LIST

Your actual files and folders, with their details.



Schematic — real windows have more buttons; these four zones never change.

STOP 08 · FILE EXPLORER

EVERY FILE HAS AN ADDRESS

C:\Users\Ana\Documents\report.docx

- the drive — the PC's main storage
- whose folder it is — one per user
- the folder — a box inside the box
- the file — .docx tells you its type

DRIVE LETTERS YOU'LL SEE

C:	The main drive — Windows and most work files live here.
D: / E:	Often USB sticks or extra drives plugged into the PC.
S: / H:	Network drives (letters vary) — shared company folders.

House rule — save to Documents or your network drive, not the Desktop or Downloads.

STOP 08 · FILE EXPLORER

SIX MOVES YOU'LL USE DAILY

COPY & PASTE	Ctrl + C, then Ctrl + V — duplicates a file where you paste.
CUT & PASTE	Ctrl + X, then Ctrl + V — moves the file instead of copying it.
RENAME	Select it, press F2 (or right-click → Rename). Clear names save you later.
NEW FOLDER	Ctrl + Shift + N — a folder a week keeps the chaos away.
SEARCH BOX	Top-right corner — searches inside the folder you're standing in.
DELETE	Delete key sends files to the Recycle Bin — your safety net.

HEADS UP **Shift + Delete** skips the Recycle Bin — gone for good. Avoid it for now.

PRACTICE · HANDS-ON LAB

YOUR 15-MINUTE LAB

Do these on your training PC. Check each one off with a partner — say out loud what you did.

1. Lock and unlock your PC with Win + L.
2. Open Settings with Win + I and find System → Storage.
3. Pin File Explorer and Settings to your taskbar.
4. In Task Manager, find which app uses the most memory.
5. In Documents, create a folder named "Lab1" and move a file into it.

Done means — you can repeat each task without notes. Practice scenario, training PCs only.

JOB AID · KEEP THIS PAGE

FIRST-WEEK CHEAT SHEET

WHEN THIS HAPPENS → DO THIS	
PC feels slow	**Task Manager (Ctrl + Shift + Esc)**
App is frozen	**Task Manager → End task**
Need an app	**Software Center → Install**
Need to change a setting	**Settings (Win + I), then search**
Can't find something	**Start search or Explorer search box**
Stepping away	**Win + L — lock it**

SHORTCUTS

Win — Start / search

Win + D — show Desktop

Alt + Tab — switch windows

Win + E — File Explorer

Win + I — Settings

Win + L — lock

Ctrl + Shift + Esc — Task Manager

Ctrl + C / X / V — copy / cut / paste

F2 — rename

YOU CAN DRIVE WINDOWS NOW.

Navigate, lock, tweak settings, watch Task Manager, install safely, connect remotely, and keep files tidy — the daily moves of a data systems administrator.

Next up — Module 02: User Accounts & Permissions.

PRACTICE · EXPLORE · ASK QUESTIONS